I SPOKE TO SBF FROM PRISON: TRUMP PARDON, GIRLFRIEND'S BETRAYAL, & LIFE IN PRISON

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Since the collapse of FTX in Nov 2022, Sam Bankman-Fried has been covered extensively by the media, largely through court filings, commentary, and third-party accounts.

This piece is different.

It is based on a direct written exchange between me and Sam while he is incarcerated and pursuing his direct appeal.

The goal was not to defend him or challenge the verdict, but to document his own explanations clearly and without interruption.

LIFE INSIDE

I asked Sam how he was doing and how the past two years had been.

He said fighting his case from prison is difficult due to limited access to legal documents and research tools, and the inability to draft or review legal filings in any meaningful way.

He described legal work as the only meaningful use of his time.

"Still trying to fight my case, though it's quite difficult to do so from prison. There's no real access to legal documents or any ability to draft legal motions in here."

He also said it has been frustrating to watch the bankruptcy process unfold while being unable to intervene.

"Seeing the bankruptcy process unfold in slow motion… that was a huge mistake on my part."

HIS BIGGEST REGRET

When asked about regret, Sam pointed to a single decision.

"By far my biggest regret is not fighting harder against the lawyers who took over FTX."

He said that once control shifted, outcomes changed.

"If I hadn't let them get away with it, all withdrawals would have been processed back in 2022, and FTX would still be operating."

He framed this as a failure rather than an issue of intent.

"When you're responsible for others, your weakness hurts them as much as it hurts you."

HIS CORE CLAIM: LIQUIDITY VS. INSOLVENCY

Liquidity, he says, is not the same as insolvency.

To explain it, he used a simple analogy:

"If someone takes out a $200k mortgage to buy a $500k house, they might not have $200k in cash. That's a liquidity issue. But they aren't bankrupt, their assets exceed their liabilities."

Sam claims Alameda Research held roughly **$25 billion in assets versus $15 billion in liabilities**, but most assets were illiquid investments, not cash.

"When the run on the bank happened in November 2022, customer withdrawals hit billions per day. FTX didn't have that much cash on hand. That's a liquidity crisis."

His argument is that liquidation, not bankruptcy, was already underway.

"Alameda still had positive net asset value. It just needed time to sell investments. Weeks, not years."

He insists that even the bankruptcy estate's early filings showed this, before those numbers were dismissed.

"WHY FILE FOR BANKRUPTCY THEN?"

Sam maintains that he did not file for bankruptcy.

"I myself never filed FTX for bankruptcy."

He said outside counsel took control and decided to file shortly thereafter.

"John Ray and Sullivan & Cromwell took control of FTX, and hours later decided to place it into bankruptcy."

He described this as the moment value was destroyed.

THE TRIAL AND THE EVIDENCE

When asked why he could not present solvency arguments in court, Sam cited court rulings.

"We were prohibited from suggesting that customers could be made whole or that FTX could satisfy withdrawals."

He also described repeated attempts to introduce Alameda balance sheets that showed positive net asset value, which he said were excluded, while the prosecution was allowed to introduce partial spreadsheets emphasizing liabilities.

He argued that terminology played a significant role.

"They used phrases like 'going negative' without defining what they meant."

According to Sam, the ambiguity allowed prosecutors to equate temporary negative balances in specific assets with insolvency.

"If I said yes, they told the jury Alameda was underwater. If I said no, they'd point to a single sub-account and say I was lying."

ON WITNESSES AND BETRAYAL

Sam does not describe former colleagues as villains.

"They were put in a really shitty position. Say what prosecutors wanted, or risk decades in prison, and even threats to their families."

He says he understands why they cooperated, even if he disagrees.

"The alternative was risking a sentence for a crime they didn't commit any more than I did."

Asked about Caroline Ellison and other former FTX executives, Sam avoided personal attacks and focused on the pressure they faced.

"I'm grateful for what they built. I'm sad the ending fucked it all up."

POLITICS AND PUBLIC IMAGE

Sam acknowledged that his public political image differed from his private views.

"Privately, I had become a centrist. I donated on both sides."

He says he avoided public political opposition to the Biden administration while running FTX to reduce regulatory retaliation.

"In hindsight, possibly a poor decision."

After his prosecution, he said his views shifted further.

"The lawfare showed exactly how dangerous it is when an administration is willing to put political opponents in prison."

THE FIRST DOMINO

Sam points to two moments.

First: **Alameda failing to hedge in 2021-2022**, during a market crash, something he says he should have overseen more closely.

Second: **one click**.

"In November 2022, I clicked a DocuSign link. The lawyers took over the company."

SIMPLIFYING HIS CASE

Near the end, I asked him how he would explain his innocence to someone with no time for technical details.

He answered this way:

"- FTX was a margin exchange. There was always run risk.
- We always had more assets than liabilities.
- When the run came, we were selling assets to meet withdrawals.
- The lawyers took over and stopped payments."

TRUMP PARDON

When asked about it, he refused to comment on the matter on record

This article does not resolve the legal questions surrounding FTX or Sam Bankman-Fried. The verdict stands, and appeals remain pending.

What it does provide is a complete, uninterrupted account of how Sam views what happened, told directly from prison, without editorial framing or selective quotation.

Readers can evaluate it on its merits.

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